themselves prisoners of Kabul.[36]

'No! No!' Abul Fazl cannot refute such 'hallucinations' hotly enough. Hakim attempted to lure away the Central Asian chiefs in Man Singh and Murad's vanguard, with letters that proposed 'acting in concert'. But, for all that the lord of Kabul may have been right about the pride of Akbar's nobility and the vortex of bitter rivalries in his court, he had underestimated the structural unity of his army. No commander in the vanguard deserted. One of them even killed the messenger who brought him Hakim's invitation to do so.

'In fine,' as Abul Fazl puts it, 'the Kabulis were dumbfounded by the might of the victorious troops.' Twice, on the 1st and 2nd of August 1581, Hakim attacked the Mughal vanguard, hoping for desertions and collapse, and suffered, instead, a resounding defeat.

Five days later, Akbar and his reluctant amirs, along with the victorious Man Singh and Murad, were camped on the outskirts of Kabul city, as 'Turk and Tajik came in droves to catch a glimpse of the emperor';[37] some of them remembering, perhaps, the child once dangled from the walls of Kabul fort, the boy who raced dogs through its courtyards, and the prince who left with his father almost thirty years ago, and was now, amazingly, the king of kings come back home.

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Akbar did not allow himself prolonged nostalgia. Once, when he was evading his tutors in this very city, his father had worried if he would acquire the discipline a ruler needs. What is growing up except a losing battle against responsibility? Akbar went into Kabul and 'remembered the places which he had seen in [his] boyhood', describing them so exactly to his amirs that Abul Fazl offers a round of applause to Akbar's 'intelligence and memory'. But he did not linger.

It would have been irresponsible to do so. Every day that Akbar spent in Kabul was driving Hakim to increasing desperation. Having been defeated on the battlefield by Man Singh and Murad, his eleven-year-old nephew, Hakim had fled a 100-odd kilometres north, to Ghorband, from where he played his trump card. He sent word that should Akbar try to arrest him, he would 'become . . . a Qalandar' and wander off into 'retirement'. This, in